



United States  
Attorney's Office  
Southern District of West Virginia



# Kentucky Nurse Sentenced to Prison for Opioid Diversion Scheme

Monday, July 7, 2025

## For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of  
West Virginia

BECKLEY, W.Va. – Jacqueline Brewster, 55, of Belfry, Kentucky, was sentenced on Thursday, July 3, 2025, to five years in prison, to be followed by three years of supervised release, for obtaining a controlled substance by fraud and wrongful disclosure of individually identifiable health information.

According to court documents and statements made in court, Brewster was employed as a travel nurse at Raleigh General Hospital in Beckley from September 2021 until February 2022. Brewster admitted that she unlawfully accessed and used individually identifiable health information of patients at Raleigh General Hospital to divert hydromorphone, an opioid, for her personal use.

To carry out her diversion scheme, Brewster fraudulently obtained the hydromorphone from automated controlled substance dispensing machines at Raleigh General Hospital. Brewster used her personal biometrics to access the machines and a patient's individually identifiable health information to begin the process of checking out hydromorphone for that patient. Once the machine's secure drawer opened, Brewster siphoned off a portion of hydromorphone from its vial and diluted what remained in the vial with another substance to make it appear full. Brewster then canceled or nulled the transaction to conceal her removal of the controlled substances.

Brewster admitted that she carried out her scheme to use individually identifiable patient health information and steal hydromorphone under false pretenses and for personal gain many times from on or about September 17, 2021, through on or about February 1, 2022.

The West Virginia Board of Registered Nurses has indefinitely suspended Brewster's privilege to practice nursing in West Virginia.

"Ensuring the integrity of the healthcare system is vital, as the diversion of medication within healthcare facilities undermines patient care and exposes patients to undue risk," said Acting United States Attorney Lisa G. Johnston. "I commend the excellent investigative work of the U.S. Food and Drug Administration–Office of Criminal Investigations (FDA-OCI) Metro Washington Field Office, and the

valuable assistance provided by detectives from the West Virginia State Police and the Kentucky State Police."

"Patients suffering from pain trust their health care providers to provide relief through effective and appropriately dosed medications," said Acting Special Agent in Charge Ronald Dawkins, FDA Office of Criminal Investigations Metro Washington Field Office. "We will continue to pursue and bring to justice healthcare professionals who violate their position of trust by diverting their patients' pain medications for their own use."

Chief United States District Judge Frank W. Volk sentenced Brewster to two years in prison for obtaining a controlled substance by fraud and to three years in prison for wrongful disclosure of individually identifiable health information, with those terms to be served consecutively. The Court concluded that Brewster's criminal conduct warranted an upward variance from the advisory guideline range of four to ten months in prison.

Assistant United States Attorney Timothy D. Boggess and former Assistant United States Attorney Owen Reynolds prosecuted the case.

A copy of this press release is located on the website of the [U.S. Attorney's Office](#) for the Southern District of West Virginia. Related court documents and information can be found on [PACER](#) by searching for Case No. 5:24-cr-104.

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*Updated July 7, 2025*



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